

CMU: Consider your application as a whole. What do you personally want to emphasize about your application? Highlight something that is important to you or something you haven't had a chance to share (300).

I would like to elaborate on my personal website. In my junior year, every student at my school completed a Capstone project in their personal area of interest. I created a website to help run my school's Model UN program more efficiently. In our conferences, we need to quickly create lists of delegates and organize timers based on those lists. My website makes it trivial. I put it online under my personal domain so anyone could use. That app was a success, but I knew that my website could be so much more. I have expanded the site with some of my other coding projects that could be useful to other people. For example, when people in my Journalism class had a hard time creating and sharing color palettes, I wrote and hosted a small app to do so. When I could not find a good tool to create news feeds, I made my own and shared it with the world through my website. Every app I host is open-source and free for anyone to use. The website continues to grow, along with the number of people using it. I put a lot of my time and mental energy into this project, but I still feel that I have only scratched the surface of its potential.

CMU: Most students choose their intended major or area of study based on a passion or inspiration that's developed over time – what passion or inspiration led you to choose this area of study (300)?

Astronomy has always been an interest of mine, even if it wasn't entirely conscious. When I was much younger, some of my favorite books were about space travel and astronauts. I loved learning about all that humans have done, looking up, and imagining it all right above my head. Nevertheless, my interest stayed on the back burner for years. I saw my laptop as much more exciting—even as I continued to watch videos about stars, galaxies, and supernovae on it. And then came Science Bowl. As part of my duty as our Earth and Space expert, I had to study astronomy in depth. I went through a textbook on it, and it blew me away. There was something truly different about seeing all that I had already known written down and rigorously explained, and that reinvigorated my passion for the cosmos. When the time came to prepare for the MIT Science Bowl competition, astronomy was my first and primary focus. I bought a new textbook and got to work. Later, while relaxing on my phone, an announcement appeared on my feed about some new astronomy competition, and I jumped at the chance. Science Bowl only happens twice a year, and beyond that I had few places to apply all that I had learned. That competition, the IAAC, ended up being fun, while also showing me much more about space. I was thrilled to apply my knowledge in a new format. It was then that I realized that I was ready to commit to the field and become an astrophysicist.

CMU: Many students pursue college for a specific degree, career opportunity or personal goal. Whichever it may be, learning will be critical to achieve your ultimate goal. As you think ahead to the process of learning during your college years, how will you define a successful college experience (300)?

My successful college experience will be one in which I can collaborate with others to learn more about all the topics that interest me. Throughout of high school, I have found many subjects that I want to delve further into that are not astrophysics. As I transition to college, a host of new opportunities will open to me that allow me to pursue these interests. I will have a much more expansive list of courses to choose from, there will be many more clubs for me to put my free time and

energy into, and I will gain the opportunity to participate in other organizations in the surrounding area. I plan to use all of these to the fullest to explore my academic interests. I could continue my interest in music by taking Physics of Musical Sound to learn about the physical basis of harmonies. Maybe I could join the Carnegie Mellon chapter of the American Meteorological Society to learn more about the atmosphere that I studied for Science Bowl. Or, I could run for the Student Senate to see the concepts that I learned in government class implemented in real life. Whatever the case, if I can look back in four years and say that I have learned more about each of my interests, then I will have had a successful college experience.

Common Application, Option 7: Write an essay of your own design.

I love Science Bowl. The endless expanse of knowledge in a fast-paced buzzer competition format yields a truly unique experience. Every year, I have taken the Science Bowl team at my school seriously and prepared for each tournament. Every team member is assigned one category to cover for the team. I was assigned Earth and Space, so astronomy and geology textbooks were on my desk a week later and reviewed within the month. Our efforts quickly bore fruit: second place at the annual statewide tournament, which also includes the private schools in our state. It was fantastic, the best our school has ever achieved at Science Bowl, and we celebrated. The excitement carried us through the night and into the next day when we stepped into school and—not much. A single mention in the morning announcements, which was largely eclipsed by the recent sports triumphs.

My school's culture revolves around the sports programs; walking into the lobby, there are innumerable trophies won from sports tournaments of years past. It looks like a sports academy. Team captains are the stars of the school. A win for the football team is a win for everyone. Meanwhile, the Science Bowl trophy is relegated to the third-floor display case, right between the rocks and bones displays. I get the hype, I play sports too. But isn't this a school?

Whenever I bring the difference up, most people say they agree with me. But culture and traditions seem to be nearly impossible to change, and everything continues the same as it always has been. I thought that I would only have to deal with this injustice in high school, and that once I got to college, academic achievement would be valued. But each morning I wake up and look at the news, I see science being attacked, and not by the jocks. Scientific grants are being frozen or cut, universities' funding is being denied, data scientists are being fired for telling the truth. I was raised to believe that scientific advancement helps us all, and I still do. I am horrified all the more to see many of our current leaders who seem to fear science and progress, and it makes me wonder who raised them.

Throughout the Science Bowl competitions, I am told again and again that my generation is the future of the world and that we will be the people in charge soon. And I have studied, earned good grades, and planned for it, all in good faith. I have prepared so that I could have a chance to make a difference. Because that's how science works: the smartest, most prepared people have the most opportunity to make an impact—like inventing a vaccine, another revolutionary development being questioned and attacked by the current administration.

I know that, someday, the pendulum will swing back, and science will be universally supported again. But until then, it's my education, my research, my future that is being scrapped. I can fight back though. I can raise awareness online. I can attend protests and get others to join me. I can demand

action from my representatives in every tier of government. I can be part of a movement to push the pendulum back, not just wait for it to happen.

But maybe that change can start right now at my high school, by valuing learning as much as athletics.

Maybe we should put the Science Bowl trophy right next to the football in the case at the front door.

Maybe, when people see that, they'll stop and think for a second.

Maybe they'll develop an appreciation for smart people.

And maybe they'll vote for them.